ROAD TO MISERY

SRI LANKA'S RULING FAMILY CHOKED ITS PEOPLE THROUGH ATROCIOUS GOVERNANCE. THEN, THE STREETS HEAVED.

2019
Soon after being elected president, Gotabaya Rajapaksa announces sweeping tax cuts as a populist measure. It leads to lost revenue, a credit rating downgrade and lack of access to foreign funds. Sri Lanka starts spending foreign reserves to meet debt.

2020
SLPP wins polls in August, Mahinda Rajapaksa is elected PM. Induction of brothers Chamal and Basil, Mahinda's son Namal, in cabinet. The pandemic hits tourism revenue, exports, remittances

2021
In April, the government bans import of chemical fertilisers as move towards 'organic agriculture'. Results in huge fall in produce, ravages farming community.

FEBRUARY-MARCH 2022
Critical lack of foreign reserves leaves nation unable to pay for vital imports like food, medicines and fuel. Massive unrest gathers mass.

MARCH 31
Protesters and activists try to storm residence of President Gotabaya Rajapaksa, demanding his resignation

APRIL 1
As protests mount, Rajapaksa declares a state of emergency



APRIL 2
A 36-hour nationwide curfew declared

APRIL 3
Most of the Sri Lankan cabinet resigns; it's a blow to Gotabaya and Mahinda

APRIL 4
Gotabaya offers to share power with the opposition, but faces calls to go. Governor of central bank, who resisted calls to seek a IMF bailout, also resigns

APRIL 5
President Gotabaya is further sidelined. Finance minister Ali Sabry resigns, he then loses his parliamentary majority as former allies urge him to quit. Emergency lifted.

burning and damaging the homes of politicians and their supporters. One Member of Parliament (MP) of the ruling party is among the nine people killed during the ongoing violence.

The protestors and Opposition parties are now adamant that Gotabaya has to resign. The euphoria around Gotabaya, a political novice but one who was showcased as an efficient administrator, began to evaporate about a year into office, as his much-touted promises to streamline the country's public sector, stop corruption and revive the economy began to fall apart. A former army officer, Gotabaya was defence minister when Mahinda was president, and was as much a hero to the masses as Mahinda for defeating the Tamil Tigers. But his inexperience in politics and over-reliance on advice from former military colleagues began to show soon after he assumed office.

The reason for the economic abyss the country has fallen into is mainly due to bad policy decisions taken by him. Political expediency overtook rational decision-making soon after his election—the president announced generous tax cuts which he said were aimed at stimulating the economy but were aimed at appeasing voters at the general elections a few months later. By April 2022, revenue losses due to tax cuts stood at a staggering Rs 500 billion (USD 1.3 billion). The country's new finance minister Ali Sabry told parliament last month that the tax cuts were a historic mistake.

ON MAY 11, GOTABAYA PROMISED TO APPOINT A NEW PM AND CABINET. THE OPPOSITION WANTS HIM TO RESIGN FIRST

Meanwhile, the outbreak of the Covid pandemic took its toll on the country's economy, which is heavily dependent on tourism, tea and garment exports and remittances from Sri Lankan workers employed overseas. Instead of providing relief, the president then went ahead with a ban on import of agrochemicals in May 2020 as part of an ad-hoc plan to move the country towards organic fertilisers. This saw a drop in the paddy crop yield in this year's harvest by over 40 per cent, turning a majority of rural Sri Lankans from farming communities—and once ardent supporters of the Rajapaksas—against them. It also resulted in soaring food prices that triggered much of the current unrest. According to the country's Department of Census and Statistics, food inflation is at a whopping 47 per cent triggered by the fertiliser ban as well as a decision to suddenly free float the Sri Lankan Rupee in March 2022. As a result, the currency, which was trading at Rs 230 against the USD, pitched to over Rs 360 to a dollar by this week. The country's foreign reserves have